DECISION READINESS NOTE (DRN–003)

TITLE: FATIGUE AS A DECISION-CAPACITY FAILURE IN OPERATIONAL ENVIRONMENTS

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Status: Anonymized | Observational | Non-enforcement

Evidence Basis: Lived Operational Exposure and Ongoing Observation

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1. Context

Domain: Operational / Industrial environments

Decision Surface: Human alertness and cognitive capacity under sustained work conditions

2. Observed Structural Pattern

- Work schedules and task designs frequently compress recovery windows.
- Observable indicators associated with fatigue persist across shifts rather than resolving between them.
- Operational decisions are required regardless of time on shift (e.g., early-morning versus mid-day vs late night hours).
- Fatigue is treated primarily as an individual discipline issue rather than a system-level capacity constraint.

3. Decision Reframe

The operative decision is not whether fatigue exists. The real decision is:

- **Does the system adjust the complexity, timing, or oversight of decisions when human cognitive capacity is in a known degradation window associated with shift timing?**

4. Decision Failure Mode

Failure Type: Assumption of Constant Capacity

The system assigns decision authority based on role (who is responsible), not state (how alert the decision-maker is at that moment).

It assumes that decisions made late in a roster or during fatigue-prone hours have equivalent reliability to those made at the start of a shift or during peak alertness.

5. Accountability Consequence

- Individuals are held accountable for errors made under predictable fatigue conditions associated with shift timing.
- Fatigue-related variance is interpreted as carelessness or lack of focus.
- Incidents are attributed to individual failure, masking misalignment between task demand and available decision capacity.

6. Decision Readiness Assessment

The system manages hours (time) and attendance (presence) but does not reliably manage:

- cognitive load relative to shift timing,
- recovery adequacy,
- decision-critical task placement (timing of high-stakes work),

As a result, decision responsibility exceeds decision capacity.

7. Minimal Diagnostic Question

When a fatigue-related error occurs, can the system demonstrate that it modified task complexity, timing, or oversight to account for the known fatigue risk associated with that shift time?

If not, the system is not decision-ready.

End of DRN–003